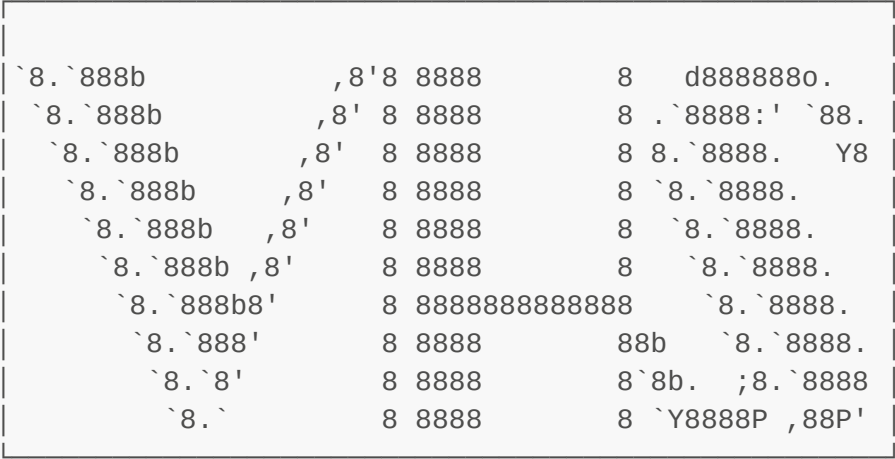


# VHS - User Guide



[[VIDEO HOSTING SYSTEM]]

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## About Video Hosting System (VHS)

VHS is a free open source digital signage service that configures a Linux-based client to boot straight into looping video(s) in fullscreen with minimal desktop overhead.

Each TV client deployed with VHS is treated as **a complete VHS instance** with its own Dropbox **media** subfolder. VHS provides the playlist builder, file watcher, and media player kiosk services, while keeping the user workflow consistent across all clients. Users only need to place their content into a TV client's Dropbox folder (e.g. **TV-XX/Now-Playing/media/video.mp4**) to automatically update the playlist for that TV.

## How to Use VHS

### Video & Playlist Management

1. Log in to Dropbox, then add the video(s) that you want to have playing on a TV into the **/Now-Playing/media** folder for that TV.
  1. **For Example:** If I want to add or remove a video from the playlist for TV-01, I would make my changes in **VHS/TV-01/Now-Playing/media/**.
2. The TV playlist (**Now-Playing/playlist.m3u**) updates automatically when the **media** folder contents change.
  1. **!** Manually editing the **playlist.m3u** files can break the VHS services.
3. Use the Archive folder (**VHS/Archive/**) to store "inactive" videos (not currently being played on any TV), that you want to keep around for easy access in the future.

### VHS Dropbox Folder Layout

```
~/Dropbox/
├── VHS/
│   ├── Archive(always excluded from sync)/
│   ├── TV-01/
│   │   ├── Now-Playing/
│   │   │   ├── media/
│   │   │   │   ├── video1.mp4
│   │   │   │   ├── video2.mp4
│   │   │   │   └── ...
│   │   │   └── playlist.m3u
│   ├── TV-02/
│   │   ├── Now-Playing/
│   │   │   ├── media/
│   │   │   │   ├── video3.mov
│   │   │   │   ├── video4.mkv
│   │   │   │   └── ...
│   │   │   └── playlist.m3u
│   └── ...
└── ...
```

- The **VHS** folder is the root Dropbox folder (**Dropbox/VHS/**).
- The Archive folder (**/Dropbox/VHS/Archive**) stores all inactive videos and *is excluded from sync on all TV clients*. Files placed here will not be played on any TV.

- Each TV has it's own **media** folder (**TV-XX/Now-Playing/media/**) where the active content for that TV is stored, along with the corresponding playlist (**Now-Playing/playlist.m3u**) file that automatically updates when the media folder contents are changed.

Dropbox allows syncing up to 3 devices for free. Adding a fourth VHS TV client will require a subscription.

## VHS TV Client Hardware

### Sleep Mode

 Your Chromeboxes are configured to "sleep" when the power button is pressed. To easily turn a VHS TV client on or off:

- A single, short press of the power button will put the box into sleep mode.
- A single, short press of the power button will wake the box to resume video playback.
- Holding down the power button will force a full shut down.

### Acer CX12 Supported Video Quality

1080p/H.264 is the safest target for reliable signage playback on this Chromebox. On a Broadwell GPU using the i965 VA-API driver, supported decode profiles include MPEG-2, H.264 (Baseline/Main/High), VC-1, JPEG, and VP8.

For reliable playback, use or re-encode video files to:

- 1080p (or lower)
- H.264
- Moderate bitrate
- Constant frame rate

This will provide a much better chance of zero-stutter looping on this hardware.

### Specs

- Make/Model: Acer Chromebox CX12
- Processor: Intel Celeron 3205U 1.5 GHz
- GPU: Intel HD Graphics (Broadwell GT1)
- RAM: 4 GB DDR3L SDRAM
- Storage: 16 GB (6 GB used, 6 GB avail. post-install)
- Video: HDMI, DisplayPort
- Networking: Ethernet, WiFi (802.11 AC)
  - Using Wi-Fi

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Developed for my friends at [Backline Music Hall](#) ♥

Full source code & license available at [github](#).

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